

TITLE

Daniela Verratti Souto

1 Introduction

1.1 Learner corpora in Second language acquisition

Collostructional analysis: Stefanowitsch and Gries (2003)

DCA: Gries and Stefanowitsch (2004)

"For studies that aim to contribute to SLA scholarship by providing insights into the progress of L2 acquisition, it will be important to analyze and compare data from learners at different proficiency levels, ideally following a longitudinal design and using corpora that capture data collected from the same learners at different points in time."

(Römer-Barron, 2026)

1.2 Formulaicity in learner language

1.3 Collostructional analysis

RQ1. How are type II conditionals dispersed across learner writing tasks and proficiency level in our analyzed data?

RQ2. Do learners at higher proficiency levels favor different verbs in the protasis of type II conditionals than beginner learners?

RQ3. Does the verbal slot in the protasis of type II conditionals provide evidence for a transition from more formulaic to more productive use of the construction?

2 Methods

2.1 Data: The EFCAMDAT

The EF-Cambridge Open Language Database (EFCAMDAT), first presented by Geertzen et al. (2013), is a large-scale learner corpus containing writings from the online English school *Englishtown*. In their courses, each level corresponds to eight pedagogical units, after each of which students receive

a prompt for a writing task that they must complete in order to advance. The corpus comprises responses to these tasks in their original and corrected forms, along with metainformation about the text and the author (learner ID, country of origin, grade given by a teacher, etc.). An advantage of the EFCAMDAT, beyond being generally available for researchers at all stages, is the fact that *Englishtown* levels are aligned with the Common European Framework of Reference (CEFR), making it possible to do a broad range of descriptive analyses of L2 English at globally understood proficiency levels.¹

This study used the version of EFCAMDAT cleaned and post-processed by (Öksüz et al., 2025), which contains 620,206 learner writings. However, it was unlikely for second conditionals to be elicited by most prompts; therefore, after qualitatively inspecting the task prompts, I decided on a subset of 20 tasks whose responses were most likely to contain the construction. The selected units and corresponding writing topics are outlined in Table 1 in Appendix A, totaling 33,496 student writings and 4,402,652 words stemming from CEFR levels A2 to C1.

Finally, to ensure sufficiently large samples of both learner texts and type II conditional instances, the writings were grouped into two proficiency bands: learners at CEFR levels A2 and B1 (“lower”) and learners at levels B2 and C1 (“upper”).

2.2 Extracting type II conditionals

All corrected learner writings in the subcorpus were automatically parsed using Stanza (Qi et al., 2020). Using the corrected texts instead of the original ones is justified by the fact that accuracy does not factor into this study: the goal is not to assess the grammatical proficiency of students, but rather to explore their lexical preferences in a specific slot in different levels. This gives us the ability to use the corrected texts that are present in the corpus, ensuring more robust results of automatic Natural Language Processing (NLP) tools.²

The parsed documents were scanned for type II conditionals using both Universal Dependency (UD) relations and part-of-speech (POS) information. Only sentences containing the word “if” as a conditional marker (headed by an *advcl* UD tag) and not as an interrogative marker headed by a *ccomp* UD tag, as in Figure 1. Then, the script ensures that the verb in the protasis is in the past tense and the apodosis contains a valid modal verb, thus filtering out other types of conditionals. For this study, I excluded sentences that expressed their conditional value through means other than the grammatical marker “if” (e.g. subject-auxiliary inversion) and sentences containing a modal verb in the protasis (e.g. *If I could go anywhere in the world, I’d go to China.*).

Finally, conditionals that fit all requirements were compiled into a CSV file with the full sentence, the lemma filling the verbal slot in the protasis, and relevant metadata about the writing prompt and

¹The availability of large-scale, CEFR-aligned corpora is more limited than one might expect. The most well-known English learner corpus is the Cambridge Learner Corpus (CLC), whose access is highly restricted.

²However, given previous robustness studies of NLP tools on L2 English (Geertzen et al., 2013), similar results would be expected when running the analysis on the original learner texts.

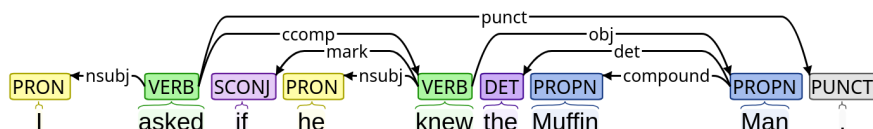


Figure 1: UD parse of a sentence with a non-conditional *if*

response, such as the *Englishtown* level the task stemmed from and the topic ID.

2.3 Calculating dispersion across tasks and levels

As a task-based corpus, the texts from EFCAMDAT are subject to task effects (Alexopoulou et al., 2017). That is, the educational environment in which the texts are embedded shapes the grammar and lexis found in the corpus. When we draw conclusions from this kind of corpora, it is possible to run into some issues if the effect of task prompts is not taken into account and we instead assume all texts to be representative of the general production of learners at their corresponding proficiency, regardless of the task. To observe the effect of task on the frequency of type II conditionals, I applied Gries's (2008) *DP* (deviation of proportions) measure and its normalized version DP_{norm} for corpus parts of unequal size as presented in the correction by Lijffijt and Gries (2012). The same process was also applied using the binary proficiency levels "upper" and "lower" as the corpus parts to ensure that the Distinctive Collexeme Analysis was carried out in comparable parts of the analyzed subcorpus.

2.4 Comparing tendencies across two L2 English proficiency levels

2.4.1 Distinctive Collexeme Analysis

2.4.2 Lexical variability

Entropy:

A measure to quantify the very different frequency distributions is relative entropy H_{rel} , a measure of uncertainty that approximates 1 as distributions become more even (as in the left panel) and that approximates 0 as distributions become more uneven and, thus, more predictable (as in the right panel). The Zipfian distributions that are so omnipresent in corpus-linguistic data typically give rise to small entropy values; see also below. In sum, both dispersion and (relative) entropy are useful but as yet underutilized corpus statistics that should be considered more often in corpus-linguistic approaches to both cognitive/usage-based linguistics as well as psycholinguistics.

Gries and Ellis (2015)

3 Results

In this section, I outline the results for each of the analyses in the study.

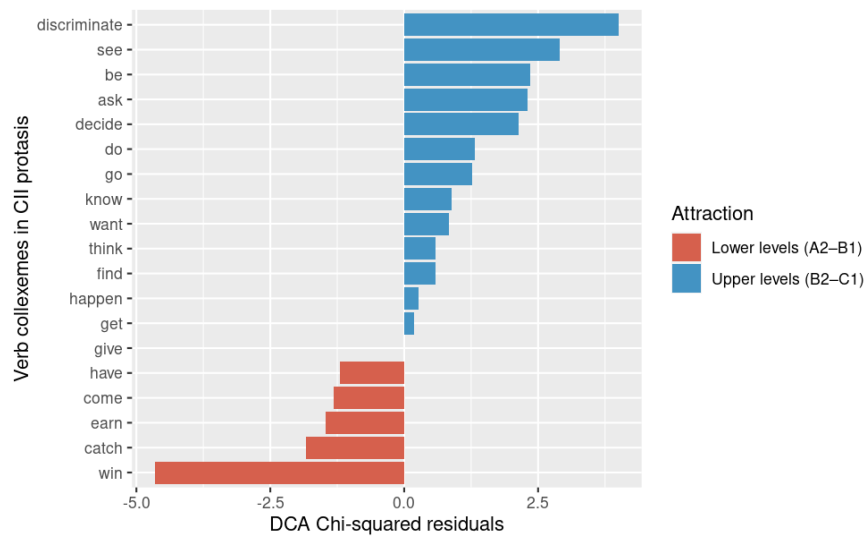


Figure 2: Residuals of the χ^2 -test

4 Discussion

5 Conclusion

Appendices

A Task topics selected for analysis

Table 1 lists all the task topics whose responses were analyzed, along with their corresponding CEFR and *Englishtown* levels.

CEFR level	EF level:Unit	Topic ID	Words	Topic
A2	6:6	46	290,594	Writing an email of advice
B1	8:3	59	474,441	Making a ‘to do’ list of your dreams
B1	9:3	67	354,123	Making a business proposal
B1	9:4	68	284,752	Signing a waiver to go skydiving
B2	10:1	73	797,218	Helping a friend find a job
B2	10:2	74	492,941	Doing a survey about discrimination
B2	10:3	75	438,282	Requesting a bank loan
B2	10:5	77	313,135	Finding a home for a wealthy client
B2	11:2	82	291,016	Helping a coworker deal with a phobia
B2	11:8	88	24,119	Improving your study skills
C1	13:1	97	244,337	Writing a campaign speech
C1	13:4	100	115,523	Giving advice about budgeting
C1	13:8	104	21,223	Reaching your potential
C1	14:2	106	41,642	Choosing a renewable energy source
C1	14:3	107	61,155	Writing a rejection letter
C1	14:4	108	55,637	Attending a seminar on stress reduction
C1	14:5	109	52,968	Talking a friend out of a risky action
C1	14:6	110	39,465	Applying for sponsorship
C1	15:7	119	5,182	Writing about future lifestyles
C1	15:8	120	4,899	Interpreting a prophecy

Table 1: Topics by Level and CEFR

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